In the meanwhile, the Passing-Out Parade (POP) of the Indian Military Academy was scheduled for 13 May 2020. Due to the unfolding Covid situation, most activities had been curtailed or cancelled. However, the POP is a once-in-a-lifetime occasion. Whether to hold a Parade or not was the question. On balance, we thought we should go through with it, and I decided that I would review the Parade myself to show the country and the world that nothing stops the Indian Army. In any case, because of social distancing and travel restrictions, parents would not be physically present but would only be able to see the live telecast. The Parade went off flawlessly, of course. In my address to the soon-to-be-commissioned Gentlemen Cadets, I stressed the importance of being ever ready for action, and the import of that was clear to everyone on account of the ongoing situation in Eastern Ladakh. For the parents, I had a special message, '*Kal tak woh aapke bacche the; kal se woh hamare bacche hain*' (till yesterday, they were your kids; from tomorrow, they are ours) in recollection of the words spoken to my mother so many years ago. The Parade marks the culmination of training, the 'Antim Pag', but it is also the 'Commencement' of an entirely new phase of life, as had been pointed out during Amala's graduation ceremony in 2012. I felt that this aspect needed to be highlighted and that the real work starts now. Accordingly, a marble plate with the words '*Pehla Kadam*' (First Step), signifying a new beginning, was placed, over which the newly commissioned officers would cross over in slow march, post the oath-taking and commissioning (pipping) ceremony. In the media interaction that followed, I was asked about the situation in Ladakh and in light of the ongoing dialogue, I replied that India as a country strongly opposed any unilateral attempts to forcefully change the status quo, but that the

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